FILMS/ OTT

GOLD STAR

Golden Globe-winning entertainment you can stream



THE POWER OF THE DOG

Netflix

There are several reasons why this Jane Campion-directed film picked up the Best Motion Picture (Drama) prize. Benedict Cumberbatch is just one of them. Tense, eerie and dark, it's a delight to watch.



THE UNDERGROUND RAILROAD

Amazon Prime Video

Winner in the Best Television Limited Series category, this adaptation of Colson Whitehead's Pulitzer-winning novel is both powerful and humane. The show's themes of slavery and freedom still resonate.

DOPESICK

Disney+ Hotstar

In this addictive show about opioid addiction, Michael Keaton plays a doctor who starts prescribing OxyContin to patients. No other actor deserved the 'Best Performance in a Limited Series' award more.



FILMS

Bringing Books Alive

Days before his latest film screens in Rotterdam, **Gurvinder Singh** explains his obsession with Punjabi literature

Director Gurvinder Singh is set to complete his trilogy based on Punjabi literature with his latest film, *Adh Chanani Raat* (English title: *Crescent Night*). Like Singh's earlier two features, *Anhe Ghore Da Daan* (premiered at the 68th Venice Film Festival) and *Chauthi Koot* (premiered at the 2015 Cannes Film Festival), even his latest feature will have its world premiere at the 52nd International Film Festival of Rotterdam (IFFR), being held later this month. Produced by Bobby Bedi, the film will play in the Harbour section of this year's IFFR.

For *Adh Chanani Raat*, Singh returns to novelist Gurdial Singh, whose work served as source material for Singh's first film as well. "I went back to Punjabi literature, so that I could go into the interiority of family life, the land-owning class of the Jatts, and find personal themes in it. Nothing arouses them more than every inch of land they own, and the people are willing to fight and die over it," Singh says over the phone from Chhattisgarh, where he's shooting his next.

At first read, Singh wasn't sure about the novel. "But then I re-read it and realised that I need not be entirely faithful to it. I think I began collaborating with my writers in 2016-17. We cracked a basic breakdown of the novel and then shot right before the first wave of the pandemic," he says.

Singh also elaborates why Gurdial Singh's work continues to fascinate him: "His understanding of atmosphere, space, light, movement, how things change according to seasons, how the inside of a house is different from the verandah...I find it all very Chekhovian."

Having emerged as one of the most assured voices in India over the past decade, Gurvinder Singh has also been vocal about issues ranging from film programming at some of the world's most prestigious film festivals to the lack of nurturing of independent voices by OTT platforms. "A lot of the film programmers don't invest enough time and effort in trying to understand cultures. I realise it's too much work, but even today they are swayed by topics like poverty, social inequality and subjugation of women—these will always be 'hot topics' in India."

He also adds how despite *Chauthi Koot* being one of the earliest Indian films to be acquired by Netflix, filmmakers like him are made to feel 'marginalised' on OTT platforms. However, that might eventually have to be the route that Singh and his producers take to release their film. "Releasing a film in the theatres is an additional expense on top of the production cost and, given the situation, I don't think there is any scope for a theatrical release right now." ■

–Tatsam Mukherjee





FILMMAKER GURVINDER SINGH FINDS INSPIRATION IN THE WORKS OF NOVELIST GURDIAL SINGH'S WORKS

Jatinder Mauhar in a still from *Adh Chanani Raat*; and (right) Gurvinder Singh